Les modaux

Règles communes

- Le modal est suivi de la base verbale, sans « to » : She can swim.
- Pas de -s à la 3e personne : He must go.
- Négation : can't / cannot, mustn't, shouldn't…

Le sens des principaux modaux

- can : capacité (I can speak English), permission (You can go).
- could : capacité dans le passé (When I was five, I could swim), demande polie.
- may : permission polie (May I open the window?), probabilité.
- might : probabilité faible (Take an umbrella, it might rain).
- must : obligation forte (You must listen), déduction sûre (He has worked all day, he must be tired).
- mustn't : interdiction (You mustn't smoke here).
- should : conseil (You should go to bed early).

Have to

- have to : obligation venant de l'extérieur, d'une règle : We have to wear a uniform.
- don't have to : absence d'obligation (ce n'est pas nécessaire) : Tomorrow is Sunday, we don't have to get up early.

mustn't ou don't have to ?

- You mustn't come = tu n'as pas le droit de venir (interdiction).
- You don't have to come = tu n'es pas obligé de venir.

Pièges à éviter

- « must to » et « can to » n'existent pas.
- Au passé, must devient had to : Yesterday I had to walk.

Teste-toi

1. You look tired. You ___ go to bed early.

A. mustn't
B. can't
C. may not
D. should

2. Tomorrow is Sunday, we ___ get up early.

A. have to
B. mustn't
C. don't have to
D. must

3. Take an umbrella, it ___ rain.

A. must not
B. can't
C. might
D. has to

4. He must ___ his homework.

A. do
B. to do
C. doing
D. does

Corrigé

1. D : Conseil : should.
2. C : Ce n'est pas nécessaire (absence d'obligation) : don't have to. Mustn't serait une interdiction.
3. C : Probabilité : might.
4. A : Après un modal : base verbale.